Arclight 0.1 - Deep Six // 0.2 - Six Pack

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/85173636.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Superheroes/Superpowers, Swearing

Language:
English

Series:
Part 2 of SPOP Sixth Anniversary Prompts, Part 1 of Arclight

Stats:
Published: 2026-05-19 Completed: 2026-05-21 Words: 3,539 Chapters: 2/2

Arclight 0.1 - Deep Six // 0.2 - Six Pack

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/85173636.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Superheroes/Superpowers, Swearing

Language:
English

Series:
Part 2 of SPOP Sixth Anniversary Prompts, Part 1 of Arclight

Stats:
Published: 2026-05-19 Completed: 2026-05-21 Words: 3,539
Chapters: 2/2

Arclight 0.1 - Deep Six // 0.2 - Six Pack

by ThiaKerrigan

Summary

Posted for the SPOP Fandom Events Sixth Anniversary Six-Pack of Six-Prompts!

Superpowered crime-fighting jock suffers cat-based home invasion.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1: Deep Six

The sky's a mess tonight. The steelwork smokestacks have been working overtime, pumping great clods of black into the lumpen grey cloudbanks, and the whole bruised blanket is underlit by the orange of the docks.

On the edge of the rent-controlled district, halfway up an anonymous grey ten-storey residential block, a cat finds a gap between a too-small air conditioning unit and a windowframe, and slips through.

It pauses on the sill, then hunkers down and hops over to a small writing desk. It paws at the spread papers, and lets out a chirp at the sight of one particular doodle.

It jumps to the floor, and with a crunch of sinew and a grunt of exertion, grows.

Adora Grey had been eight years old when her powers had come in - even that young, she'd known to lie to the Board.

She rolled her shoulder, adjusting her gym bag as she finally reached her residential block. There weren't many sparks out there who could meaningfully challenge the She-Ra in a fight - but tonight she'd had the privilege of duking it out with Rogel-Ten, an inscrutable cyborg the size of a fridge with some kind of material strengthening subpower that gave him a hell of an edge.

She took the stairs methodically. They were just a fact of life now, the stairs and the perpetually broken elevator they wrapped around. Twelve steps up then twelve paces round to the next flight. It was almost a shame she didn't live on the twelfth floor.

She chuckled at herself and kept going.

Her apartment door, thin and absolutely not up to fire code, mercifully let her in after only two jiggles of the key.

She dropped her gym bag, and let out a slow groan.

"I thought I'd have to do a lot more work to get you to make noises like *that*."

Adora yelped, hit the lightswitch.

"Nu-uh," the voice said - warm, rough, menacing - as Adora realised the lights hadn't come on. "Sneaking into a hero's apartment 101 - kill the lights."

Adora squinted into the darkness, the last bit of light-blindness from the stairwell leaching out of her eyes. Someone was sitting on her comfy* chair.

(the one with the two-dollar thrift shop cushion and the fewest splinters)*

"Relax, She-Ra. I'm not here to hurt you."

Adora blinked twice more, and the figure shifted, and she finally saw the pair of reflecting retinas in the dark.

"Wait. Catra?"

There was a pause.

"Seriously? We haven't fought *that* often, have we?"

"I... have a good memory for voices?" Adora was very glad for the darkness all of a sudden. The faint orange streetlights through the curtains couldn't possibly illuminate her blushing... could they?

"Ugh, and here I was trying to be mysterious and everything. Should have known a dork like you would find a way to ruin it." The figure stood, and stalked forward, and jabbed an accusatory finger toward Adora's chest.

"Are... are you wearing my *clothes*?" Adora's voice lifted into a squeak, and she almost wished* for the earth to open up and devour her then and there.

(Adora had long since learned that wishing for anything too hard, with her powers, was a risky endeavour)*

"You're damn right I am," Catra growled. "I don't get to keep mine when I shift, unlike *some* meathead *mahou-shoujo* I could name."

Adora swallowed and forced herself to look away from Catra's collarbone, where one of Adora's pyjama t-shirts (Blackwing Horde's 2022 tour) hung *domestically* low.

And then she realised. "You're a shifter as well? Your street rating is like, Exo Focus Fire I think? I thought shifting was full Endo?"

"Lesson 102," Catra purred. "Never let anyone know your real ratings. But you'd know all about that, huh?"

Adora's breath came shallow. "Catra... you're not wrong. But this is really starting to scare me. Will you please tell me what's going on?"

"You," Catra placed a fingertip on Adora's chest, making contact this time, and Adora swallowed. "smashed up a meth lab yesterday. So not only did you fuck with my street supply of ADHD meds, you also pissed off the guy bankrolling the joint."

"I've dealt with drug lords before, Catra, I-"

"It was one of Prime's. Or rather, it was the third one of Prime's that you've wrecked in the last calendar month."

Adora's mouth stayed exactly where it was.

"Now she's getting it. You're not just fucked, *She-Ra*. You're chained up in a cargo container on the way to the capital city of Fuckberg, in the non-extradition country of Fuckania."

"Oh... fuck."

"*Exactly*." Catra turned away, stretched her arms over her head, stalked back over to the comfy chair with Adora's band shirt draped over her shoulders and Adora's favourite plaid pyjama shorts hanging treacherously low on her hips. "Thing about the She-Ra is, she's made a lot of big enemies. But it turns out she's also made enough friends that they called on me to come help you out."

"...but it's Prime," Adora muttered. "Has he ever solved a problem without casualties?"

"Not really." Catra's voice lost some of its levity.

A flock of headlines from the last few years fluttered through Adora's memory. *Mass Psychosis at Stadium*. *Brawl Escalates, Fifteen Dead*. *Eternia Tenement Fire Claims Thirty-Seven Lives*.

"There's a little old lady downstairs." Adora reeds out, in a voice that sounds like the eight-year-old girl who broke down the day her brother was drafted to the army never to be seen again. "Razz Carmichael. Barely knows what year it is. Brings me a berry pie every month. There's no way she could take care of herself if Prime came here. Oh fuck. Catra. Fuck. What have I done? What have I-"

"Hey." Catra snapped her fingers, loud, and something washed through Adora's head. "Hakuna your tatas. He doesn't know where you are yet. But he's posted a Deep Six bounty that could pay off God, so the countdown's ticking down quick. You've been good at covering your tracks, so it'll take them time to find you. And even though it's a big damn bounty, it's not Prime's brand of 'personal attention'. So your little old lady downstairs should be fine. But your friends called the Railroad, and paid for the deluxe package, so you are coming with me *tonight*."

Adora finally leaned back against the doorframe, and let herself slide to the ground. "Give me... give me a minute."

"You've got half an hour. Pack everything you want to keep. Two bags max." Catra said, leaning back on the chair. "Fuck, how do you even have a spine? Where did you get these chairs, *Dyspraxic Carpenters Bulk Discounts* or some shit?"

"They're thrifted," Adora muttered. "Mattress is through the partition. It's... a bit more comfortable?"

"You don't sound convinced of that," Catra chuckled.

Adora started to pack.

Chapter 2: Six Pack

Two bags. Adora had a lot of things, but in the way you own things when you live in one place for six years and never quite decide which junk drawer to throw out. Two bags and the threat of death by Prime gave her a remarkable amount of focus on what was worth keeping.

The shoebox. Idents, passport, the photograph of Adam in his uniform. The cash roll from behind the loose skirting board. Necessaries from the bathroom cupboard. Protein bars. Clothes - seven of each underthing, three of each outer.

Then the kit - a flat black case about the size of a hardback novel, which she opened to check everything was there. Coil, needles in their sealed sleeves, the little bottles of ink ranked by colour. She zipped it shut and slotted it down the spine of her duffel.

"...the fuck?"

Adora glanced up. Catra had pulled back the partition and was lying on the mattress, leaning up on one elbow, head tilted, ears not technically pointed but doing a damn good impression of it.

"Huh?"

"Was that what I think it was?"

"...what did you think it was?" she countered lamely.

"*She-Ra*." Catra was up off the mattress now, and across the floor in three steps that were entirely too quiet for someone in bare feet on cheap laminate. "Are you *tattooing* people in your *apartment*?"

"I'm tattooing *me* in my apartment. Mostly. And it's Adora." Something in her prickled at the ease with which she'd said her name.

"Adora. Huh. Kinda lame name for someone who tattoos themselves. Mostly."

"Sometimes friends." Adora cinched the duffel closed. "I'm clean about it. Autoclave's too heavy to bring but I have five sterile needles, I -"

"You have an *autoclave*."

"It's a small one...?"

Catra made a noise that wasn't quite a laugh and wasn't quite a wheeze. "She-Ra. *The* She-Ra. Fucking... *pillar* of civic virtue. Has a backroom tattoo operation."

"It's not a backroom, it's the living room. And it's not a hobby, it's... necessary." Adora pressed her lips together. "What the hell," she muttered. "You've got undeclared powers too, mine are hardly going to surprise you." She straightened up, dropped her hands to the hem of her long-sleeved white turtleneck, and pulled it off.

"Oh shit," Catra said.

"Yeah."

Clove and orange swirled through the air as Catra, just a little closer than Adora was ready for, examined Adora's arms. "So - let me work it out - a kid Adora goes out on patrol. And she takes, what, a sketchbook?"

"Journalist's pad."

"Mm. Because her power says, if you can draw it, and hold on to the paper, and imagine it hard enough, it's real. Am I on the right path?"

Catra looked up at her, still so close, and her two-coloured eyes glittered in the low light, and Adora fought to keep her breath under control.

"Pretty much," she managed.

"And maybe it's her first time out, or maybe she gets lucky for a few nights, but eventually she finds out just how fragile paper is when you're getting in full-stakes fights with other sparks."

Adora chuckled ruefully. "First night. I hadn't even made it out of the subway station before someone barged me and I dropped it in a puddle."

"Oh *honey*," Catra laughed - a sound that Adora realised she desperately wanted to hear again - and put a fingertip on one of the thirty-three tattoos scattered over Adora's body - the She-Ra armour on her upper left arm. "And this kid realises there's a way to draw what she wants and hold on to the drawing no matter what happens."

"I started with permanent markers," Adora clucked her tongue. "No, that's a lie. I *started* with Sharpies. Had to top them up on the daily to keep the She-Ra from looking like a ghost. Now I just have a rule. Anything I have to draw five times, becomes a tattoo."

Catra was quiet for a beat. "I was going to joke about tat sleeves being damn hot with arms like yours. But fuck, that's... weirdly heavy."

"I guess," Adora said, and pulled the turtleneck back on.

"I'm filing this under *things I get to bring up later*."

"There isn't going to *be* a later if we don't -"

"Of course there's going to be a later." Catra's voice flattened, just slightly, and Adora felt it like a hand on her sternum. "Now if you're done packing, hold still a sec. I need to do a thing."

"What kind of thing?"

"The kind of thing I'd rather explain after, because if I explain first you'll get weird about it."

"That is *absolutely* not reassuring."

"I know." Catra stepped in close. "Skin contact. Where-ever's fine."

Adora held out her wrist. Catra's fingers settled over the pulse - warm, dry, a little rough at the pads where the fur would be in the other shape - and Adora's whole arm reported back in detail she didn't need.

"Okay," Catra murmured. "Hold."

It wasn't a sensation, exactly. It was the absence of a sensation Adora hadn't known she was carrying. Something at the base of her skull unbuttoned. There was a stretch, a give, like a door she'd assumed was a wall finally opening, and then...

A thread. The shape of someone *there*, on the other end of a line. Focused. A little tired. A flicker of something warmer that smoothed itself flat before Adora could name it.

"What...?"

"Don't." Catra let go. The thread didn't. "Don't push at it. You'll get a headache. Just let it sit."

"You..." Adora pressed the heel of her hand against her temple. "Catra. Did you just... rewire my brain?"

"Lent you a piece of something I've been carrying." Catra stepped back. *Short range. I think these words loud and on purpose, and you hear them. You should get an impression of intent as well. Useful in case of emergencies. Goes both ways.*

"Both ways?"

"Yes, dumbass. I can feel you panicking, for instance."

"I am *not*, I am *processing* -"

"Sure you are. Now calm the fuck down and help me calibrate. Repeat after me." *Orange*.

"Orange?"

Think it at me, dumbass.

Adora closed her eyes, and breathed, and imagined pushing the thought to Catra: *Orange*.

"Oh, weird. I got the colour. Okay, again." *Mangrove.*

Mangrove.

"Good. Now tell me what I'm about to do."

Adora raised her hand to block the incoming slap, and opened her eyes.

Catra smirked up at her, both hands behind her back. "Good," she said. "We're set. Look away."

"What...?"

Look away, Grey.

Adora put her hands over her eyes. There was the soft fabric-sound of the shirt and shorts hitting the floor, a sound she couldn't have described to anyone, somewhere between a sigh and a knuckle popping, and then a small, dense thump along with the thread trailing from the base of her skull compressing - not gone, just smaller, more pointed, more *animal*.

okay

Adora opened her eyes.

A cat sat on her cheap laminate floor with its tail curled neatly around its paws and looked up at her, unimpressed.

"Right." Adora knelt, scooped up the pyjama shirt and shorts, folded them with a precision she suddenly felt very stupid about, and tucked them into the outer pocket of her duffel. "...just in case. Okay."

The cat made a small sound as the word *good* arrived in her head.

"This is going to be a long night, isn't it."

The thread said *yahuh* in a way that somehow contained every time Catra had called her an idiot since she'd walked in the door.

She shouldered the duffel and the sports bag, looked at her apartment, said goodbye to it for who knew how long.

"Lead the way, alleycat."

*i **will** trip you*

They went down the stairs the way she'd come up - twelve and twelve, twelve and twelve - except this time she was carrying her life on her shoulders and a small brown tabby was pouring herself down the banister one landing ahead.

The cat paused on the third-floor landing. Adora paused with her. The thread flickered: *wait*, then *clear*, then *move*.

Razz's door was on the second floor. Adora told herself, very firmly, not to look. But the little wreath of dried lavender was still pinned to the knocker, and the mat still said WELCOME in faded green, and she still couldn't quite convince herself that Razz was going to be safe.

The thread tugged. Not impatient. Just *present*. Adora swallowed something thick and kept walking.

Out the side door, past the bins, into the alley where the orange of the docks didn't quite reach. The cat was a smudge of motion

against the wet asphalt. Adora kept her pace easy, hands free, the duffel high and tight against her back.

"How far?"

The thread said *two*, and then a shape Adora chose to interpret as *blocks*, and then, with a flatness that read as humour, *shut up*.

You shut up.

The cat's tail flicked.

They came up on the pickup point from the west, the way you would if you were being careful and not the way you would if you were being fast. A laundry truck idled at the kerb under a busted streetlight. The driver's window was rolled down two fingers. The wing mirror had been folded in.

The thread went tight, and cold, and *still*.

Adora stopped walking before she'd consciously decided to. *What?*

wing mirror

The mirror's folded.

folded in safe. folded out safe. folded in and antenna up -

The antenna was up.

"*Oh*," Adora breathed. "Oh, that's clever. That's actually -"

The thread snapped: *RUN*.

They ran.

Adora didn't look back at the truck. She heard it, though - the soft cough of a door, the scuff of a boot finding traction. Two boots. More. The thread in her skull went bright and narrow and Catra was already a streak of motion ten metres ahead and turning into an alley Adora hadn't seen, and Adora went after her.

The duffel rode high. The sports bag bit her shoulder. She didn't have time to care.

The alley dead-ended in a chain-link fence at chest height; Catra was over it already. Adora measured it, set a hand, vaulted, landed in a roll that absorbed most of the duffel's argument with her spine, and was up and running. The thread said *left* and she went left. *up* and she went up - a fire escape, the ladder already down because Catra had hit it with enough mass on the way past to drop it. She took it two rungs at a time.

The roof was flat tar and gravel and a thousand puddles each holding their own piece of orange sky. Catra was half a roof ahead, a flicker of brown against grey. The thread said *gap*, and Adora saw it - a four-foot drop to the next building over, an alley below it lit by one stubborn sodium bulb - and she told herself not to think about it, because thinking about it would make it impossible.

Her mind betrayed her again. She thought: *I have done worse with worse shoes*.

She jumped. She landed into the roll, and bruised the hell out of her shoulder, and kept going.

She *really* needed to finalise the hang-glider tattoo design.

Behind her, some distance back, someone shouted in a language she didn't recognise and someone else answered in one she did, and the thread on her skull went *faster*, and Adora found that there was, in fact, a faster.

She lost track of the route somewhere around the seventh roof. The thread did the navigation; she did the legs. Down a fire escape that ended six feet above a dumpster - she took the dumpster, took the asphalt, took a service door Catra had already slipped under and which Adora had to shoulder hard. Down a stairwell that smelled like piss and pigeons. Out into a basement

corridor she wouldn't have known existed if she'd lived in this neighbourhood for sixty years.

A door labelled *Service Only*. A keypad. Catra at her feet, looking up.

code's in your head now, the thread said, with what Adora was beginning to recognise as the cat-shaped equivalent of a smirk. *type it.*

"You... are..." Adora managed between breaths, then realised the thread wasn't predicated on her lungs. *You are such an ass.*

She typed it.

The door clicked. They went through.

It was a room.

That was the first and most generous thing Adora could say about it. It was a room, and there was a mattress on the floor in one corner with a folded grey blanket on it, and a kettle and a box of teabags on a wooden crate, and a single bare bulb on a chain, and a steel door with three deadbolts, all of which Catra was - still as a cat, sitting up on her haunches on what would look like a key shelf to anyone else but Adora was *certain* she'd put there for exactly this purpose - flipping into place one at a time.

The thread settled. The narrow brightness of the chase smoothed out into something duller and slower and, Adora realised after a beat, *tired*.

The cat padded over to the mattress. Sat on it. Looked at her.

rest

"I'm fine, I can-"

rest. Flatter this time. *down. mattress.*

"Catra, I am running on adrenaline and panic, I'm not going to be able to..."

The cat blinked at her, slow, and the thread did something Adora could only describe as *leaning*. Something like the voice of a parent who knew exactly how their kid's sugar trip was about to end, set against the back of Adora's neck like a hand.

Adora set down the duffel. Set down the second bag. Toed off her boots, lined them up against the wall the way she'd been taught at eight years old and never managed to un-learn. Lay down on the mattress.

It was a cot mattress on bare concrete. She realised with a scowl that it was more comfortable than the one back in her apartment.

The cat walked up the length of her, paws careful, and settled on her abdomen with the particular dense weight of an animal that has decided this is where it lives now. Adora put a hand, very lightly, on the cat's back.

The thread said *sleep*, and Adora, who hadn't expected to be able to, did.

End Notes

You ever have something click and think oh, did i just get my *voice* back?

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!